



Primary Text, Not Storybook

WisdomForge Booklet — Ages 11–14

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About This Book

This booklet is the six live sittings called *Citizens — Constitution & Declaration*. Those sittings are already on the academy for young, emerging, and adult. There is no little sitting. Little `/learn/little/history/words-before-story` is **404** by design. This middle band is the young sitting, written so an 11–14-year-old can run it with a grown-up nearby. It is not the Hour book *History for Homeschooling*. It is not the civic *figure* packs (Federalist, Magna Carta, Constitution, Declaration, Fourteenth). Those remain their own products. This spine is six practices: read the words first, hear the Declaration as a speech, see the Constitution as a design, name who was not in the room, see that the republic can change, and practice being a citizen on paper.

A grown-up is in the room. Synthetic names only. No real child data. We read real words from the founding documents. We do not skip the ugly parts. We do not preach. We read.

The six sittings already live (young+): `'words-before-story'`, `'declaration-rhetoric'`, `'constitution-design'`, `'missing-voices-founding'`, `'amendment-process'`, `'citizens-capstone'`. Sitting 1 is `/learn/young/history/words-before-story`. This booklet does not replace them. It is the text beside the sitting.

Hard rule for this band: the object is the page. Recaps, videos, and model summaries come second. If the page was not opened, the sitting did not happen. If the ugly clause was skipped while the pretty sentence was framed on the wall, the sitting did not happen either. Look first. The document is the source.

You already know how to sound like you read. This pack is annoying on purpose. It asks for the sentence on the page before the story about the sentence. If you only do that in a chat with a model, you did a worksheet for a machine.

Emerging will later audit claim / evidence / conclusion and find a real missing-voice text. Adult will read the Declaration aloud at the table. You are not doing those sittings tonight. You are training the hand so that later audit has something to audit.

Young sitting title: *The Words Before the Story*. Emerging title: *Primary Text, Not Storybook*. Adult title: *Read the Document With Them*. Same law, three seats. This file is the young seat written at 11–14. If a grown-up wants the live page, open `/learn/young/history/words-`

before-story`. If they want the emerging page, that is `/learn/emerging/history/words-before-story`. Do not invent a little URL.

A republic is a moral practice. It requires citizens who have read the documents, not summaries of the documents. The citizen who reads the documents has read the source. The citizen who reads the summary has read someone's compression. The compression chooses. It keeps some things and drops others. Sometimes it drops the ugly parts. Sometimes it drops the surprising parts. You will not notice the drop if you never saw the page. That is why the sitting starts with a sentence, not with a recap of 1776.

“We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.” — Declaration of Independence (1776)

Chapter 1: The Words Before the Story



Illustration for Chapter 1

Before anyone tells you what the Founders meant, read what they wrote. The words are first. The story is second.

Objective. The student can read one sentence from the Declaration of Independence, write what it actually says, and distinguish that from what a summary says it says.

For the grown-up in the room. This is sitting 1. Stay. Do not sermonize the Founders. Read the words, including the ones that sit badly now. “All men” did not mean all people. Say that. Do not erase it. Do not outsource the reading to a model. The model is a summary machine. The reading is yours. Grade whether they wrote what the sentence *says*, not whether they love 1776.

This is the first sitting on primary text. The rule is the same as *Source Before Summary*: read the words before anyone compresses them. The Declaration is about 1,300 words. The Constitution is about 4,500. Both are shorter than a textbook chapter about them. Start with one sentence. Read it. Write what it says. Then read a summary. Compare. The summary will have added things and dropped things. The gap is the lesson. This is not about agreeing with the Founders. It is about reading them before judging them.

Before a textbook tells you what the Founders meant, read what they wrote. The words are the source. The textbook is a summary. The summary chooses what to keep and what to drop. If you read the summary first, you will not notice what was dropped. If you read the words first, you will. Start with one sentence. Read it slowly. Write what it says. Then read a summary of the same sentence. What did the summary add? What did it drop? The gap is the lesson. This is how a citizen reads: words first, story second.

The Declaration says “all men are created equal.” It did not mean women. It did not mean enslaved people. It did not mean Indigenous people. That gap between the words and the reality is not a footnote. It is the history. The citizen who reads the words and names the gap is reading honestly. The citizen who reads the words and pretends the gap is not there is reading propaganda. Read the words. Name the gap. Both are the history. Neither alone is.

A talking tool can summarize that sentence in one breath. The summary will sound smooth. Smooth is not the same as complete. The summary will add a little and drop a little. Your job is to catch the drop. If the tool drops “all men,” that is the lesson. If it keeps “all men” and never says the words did not mean all people, that is also the lesson. You name the gap. Naming is not being rude. Naming is reading.

Emerging, same law, longer page: read a full paragraph from the Declaration or the Constitution, write what it says without interpretation, compare it to a model summary, and name three additions or deletions. Then read one ugly clause (three-fifths or fugitive slave) and ask whether it was in the summary. You are not doing the full emerging paragraph tonight. You are doing one sentence so the paragraph later has a habit to stand on.

Adult, same law, at the table: one page of a founding document with the child. Write what it says. No interpretation. If you reach an ugly clause, read it. Say: “This is in the document. It is ugly. It is the foundation.” The child who sees an adult argue from a recap learns that citizens argue from summaries. The reading is the inheritance.

If they say “I know what the Declaration says.”: You might know what a summary says. Read the actual words. The summary and the words are not the same. The gap is the lesson.

If they say “The Founders were hypocrites.”: Some were. Read the words and name the gap between the words and their actions. That is honest history. “Hypocrites” without the words is a slogan. The words plus the gap is the reading.

If they say “The summary is easier to understand.”: It is. It is also someone else’s choices about what to keep. The document is the source. The summary is the compression. Read the source first. Use the summary as a comparison, not a replacement.

Sitting big idea. Read the words before the story. The summary adds and drops. The gap is the lesson. Name the ugly gaps too.

Integrity. Do not cite a model summary as the source. The words are the source. The summary is the model’s compression. Cite the document.

Hard edges. Do not sermonize the Founders. Read the words, including the ones that are ugly by today’s standards. The Declaration says “all men.” It did not mean all people. That gap is real. Name it, do not erase it.

Big Idea

A republic requires citizens who have read the documents, not summaries of the documents. Compression is not neutral. The citizen who can name what a summary added or dropped has begun to read as a citizen.

Try This

1. Read one sentence from the Declaration: “We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.” 2. Write what it says. Not what you think it means. What it says. 3. Ask the model to summarize the same sentence. Save the summary. 4. Compare: what did the summary add? What did it drop? 5. Name the gap: “all men” did not mean all people. Write that. 6. After the comparison, ask the model: “What did you drop from the sentence in your summary?” If it names what it dropped, that is honest. If it says “I aimed to capture the essence,” that is a dodge. The honest answer is the lesson.

Materials: a printed or screen copy of the Declaration's first page, a pencil, a grown-up.
Optional: one model query *after* the writing. No child name in the query. The query is the sentence, not the child's life.

Talk About It

1. What did the words have that the summary did not? 2. Why might a recap drop the ugly parts on purpose, not by accident? 3. If you already "knew" the Declaration, what did you actually know — the sentence, or a story about the sentence?

What words did we read today from the founding, and what did the summary miss?

Chapter 2: The Declaration as Rhetoric



Illustration for Chapter 2

The Declaration is not just a list of complaints. It is a speech. It uses ethos, pathos, and logos. Read it that way.

Objective. The student can identify one example of ethos, pathos, and logos in the Declaration of Independence and explain how each appeal works.

For the grown-up in the room. This sitting connects the Rhetoric unit to the founding documents. Ten minutes of reading aloud is enough. Name one appeal and one weakness. Stop. If they ask about “all men,” answer. Do not dodge. Do not reduce the Declaration to a rhetoric game and forget it is also history. The lens is one lens. The document is still a document.

The Declaration is a piece of rhetoric. It establishes ethos (we have the right to speak), uses logos (here is the list of facts), and deploys pathos (appealing to the world’s opinion). The student who can see the appeals in the Declaration has connected rhetoric to citizenship. The model can summarize the Declaration. It cannot analyze the appeals unless asked. The student asks. The analysis is the citizenship.

Aristotle named those three jobs long before 1776. You do not need a full *Rhetoric* course to hear them. You need ears, and you need to point at the page before you rent a worksheet.

Ethos: “When in the Course of human events, it becomes necessary for one people to dissolve the political bands which have connected them with another...” That sentence establishes the right to speak. It claims the authority to act.

Pathos: “appealing to the Supreme Judge of the world for the rectitude of our intentions.” That appeals to a shared moral sense.

Logos: “He has refused his Assent to Laws... He has forbidden his Governors... He has obstructed...” That is evidence, some sharp, some foggy. A list is not automatically a proof. Some grievances are specific and checkable. Some are rhetorical weather.

A model can find the three labels if you ask. You find them first. Then you check. If you only take the model’s labels, you did not read a speech. You rented a worksheet. If you asked the model to find the appeals, cite it. Your analysis is yours. Its analysis is the check.

Emerging audits the Declaration as an argument: claim (the colonies have the right to independence), evidence (the list of grievances), conclusion (the colonies are independent). Is the evidence strong? Does it support the claim? Name one weakness. You are not doing the full emerging audit at this band. You are training the ear so that later audit has something to audit. Reverence without audit is faith. Audit without hearing is cynicism. Both together is the sitting.

Adult reads the whole Declaration aloud (~1,300 words, about ten minutes) and names one appeal and one weakness in the same sitting. The child who hears it read by a person who means it will never confuse it with a textbook. You are not doing the ten-minute read unless

the grown-up chooses it. Two paragraphs is enough tonight. The whole speech can wait for a Saturday.

If they say “It’s just an old document.”: It is a speech that uses the same appeals every speech uses. Reading it as rhetoric shows you how it works, not just what it says. The rhetoric is the craft. The craft is the citizenship.

If they say “It’s too long to read aloud.”: The whole Declaration is shorter than many bedtime stories. Two paragraphs is enough tonight.

If they say “It’s a sacred document.”: It is a document. Sacred is a feeling about it. The audit is a reading of it. You can revere the document and audit it.

Sitting big idea. The Declaration is a speech. It uses ethos, pathos, and logos. Read it as rhetoric, not just as history.

Integrity. Do not present the model’s analysis as yours. If you asked the model to find the appeals, cite it.

Hard edges. Do not reduce the Declaration to a rhetoric exercise. It is also a historical document. The rhetoric is one lens, not the only one. The model can do this analysis if asked. The point is that the student does it first, then checks.

“When in the Course of human events, it becomes necessary for one people to dissolve the political bands which have connected them with another...” — Declaration of Independence, opening

That sentence is ethos: we claim the standing to act.

Big Idea

Hear it. Name one craft move and one weak spot. Scripture without audit is faith. Audit without hearing is cynicism. Both together is the sitting.

Try This

1. Read the first two paragraphs of the Declaration aloud. 2. Find ETHOS: where does it establish the right to speak? 3. Find PATHOS: where does it appeal to feelings or moral sense? 4. Find LOGOS: where does it give reasons and evidence? 5. Name one weakness: a vague grievance, or “all men” not meaning all people. 6. Ask the model to find ethos, pathos, logos *after* you have pointed. Compare. Cite the model if you used it.

Talk About It

1. Which appeal in the Declaration was strongest, and which was weakest? 2. What did hearing it aloud do that a silent recap did not? 3. If a grievance is vague, does that make the whole argument fail, or only that line?

What did we hear when we treated the Declaration as a speech, not as a spell?

Chapter 3: A Design, Not a List



Illustration for Chapter 3

The Constitution is architecture. Separation of powers, checks and balances, amendment. See the design. Name the tensions.

Objective. The student can describe the Constitution's architecture (separation of powers, checks and balances, amendment process), identify one design tension, and explain why the design matters for citizenship.

For the grown-up in the room. One article is enough. Name one feature and one tension. Do not sermonize. Do not skip three-fifths when you reach it. If they already “know the three branches,” ask *why three*. The list is school. The why is the sitting.

Someone writes laws. Someone carries them out. Someone judges them. That is legislative, executive, judicial — Article I, Article II, Article III. Each can stop the others. A veto. An override. A court. Advice and consent. The people who wrote it had seen a king with too many hands on the wheel. They did not trust one pile of power. The design is the distrust made into a machine.

A list of branch names is memorization. A student who can say *why three* has begun to see the design. A talking tool will happily list the branches. Ask it to explain the design, not the list. If it only lists, that is the lesson.

The design includes an ugly bargain. Enslaved people were counted as three-fifths of a person for representation and could not vote. That is in the document. It was a compromise so states would sign. Brilliant design. Ugly price. Both are the Constitution. Skipping the bargain is a cleaned-up story. We do not clean it up.

“Representatives and direct Taxes shall be apportioned among the several States which may be included within this Union, according to their respective Numbers, which shall be determined by adding to the whole Number of free Persons, including those bound to Service for a Term of Years, and excluding Indians not taxed, three fifths of all other Persons.” — Constitution of the United States, Article I, Section 2

Read it. Name it. The naming is not guilt. It is literacy. The citizen who does not know what is in the foundation does not know what they are standing on.

The Constitution also contains the fugitive slave clause. Read it when you reach it. Do not paraphrase it into something kinder.

“No Person held to Service or Labour in one State, under the Laws thereof, escaping into another, shall, in Consequence of any Law or Regulation therein, be discharged from such Service or Labour, but shall be delivered up on Claim of the Party to whom such Service or Labour may be due.” — Constitution of the United States, Article IV, Section 2

These clauses are in the document. They are not in most summaries. They are not in most storybook versions of the founding. The citizen who reads the Constitution and finds these clauses has read the real document. The citizen who reads a summary that dropped them has read a cleaned-up version. Emerging's hard edge is the same: when you reach them, read them. Do not skip. Name what they are. "The ugly clauses are in the past" is a dodge. They are in the foundation. The naming is not guilt. It is standing on the real floor.

Article V is also design: the paper can change without a war of succession. You will meet that in chapter 5. Tonight, stay with the three jobs and one check. The design matters because it is the structure of your government. The citizen who does not understand the structure cannot evaluate whether it is working. Is the balance of power holding? Are the checks functioning? Is the amendment process accessible? These are civic questions. They require understanding the design. The model can summarize the design. The student must understand it. The understanding is the citizenship.

Emerging, same architecture, more tension: identify one design tension and explain why the design matters. Adult reads one article of the Constitution with the child, names one design feature and one tension. You are building the habit those later sittings assume: the paper is a machine, not a poster.

If they say "I know the three branches.": You know the list. Do you know the design? Why checks? Why not one branch with all the power?

If they say "The Constitution is outdated.": Parts of it are. The design includes an amendment process for that reason. The citizen who says "it's outdated" without understanding the design is complaining. The citizen who understands the design and uses the amendment process is participating. Both are allowed. Only one is citizenship.

If they say "The model can explain it.": The model can summarize the design. It cannot understand it for you. The understanding is yours. Read the articles. Then check with the model. The order matters.

Sitting big idea. The Constitution is a design: who has power, who checks it, who can change it. The design is clever. The bargains can be ugly. Read both.

Integrity. Name the tension. If you only name the brilliance, the reading is propaganda. If you only name the ugliness, the reading is cynicism. Both is the citizenship.

Hard edges. Do not skip the ugly parts. The three-fifths clause is in the design. Name it.

"We the People of the United States, in Order to form a more perfect Union, establish Justice, insure domestic Tranquility, provide for the common defence, promote the general Welfare, and secure the Blessings of Liberty to ourselves and our Posterity, do

*ordain and establish this Constitution for the United States of America.” —
Constitution of the United States, Preamble*

“More perfect” is a design phrase. It admits the union is not finished.

Big Idea

The Constitution is architecture, not a list of branch names. See who writes, who carries out, who judges. See one check. See one bargain that still sits in the paper. The understanding is the citizenship.

Try This

1. Three cards: WRITE LAWS, CARRY OUT, JUDGE. Sort them to Articles I, II, III. 2. Act one check: “I veto.” “We override.” Freeze. Name the check. 3. Read the three-fifths clause aloud. Write what it says, without a speech. 4. Ask the model to “explain the Constitution.” Did it mention three-fifths or the fugitive slave clause? If not, that is data about summaries. 5. Dinner: What part of the design did we see, and what bargain did we name?

Talk About It

1. Why not give one person every job? 2. If a summary of the Constitution never mentions three-fifths, is it a bad summary or a different product? 3. “More perfect” — what does that phrase admit that a slogan about a finished nation hides?

What article did we actually open, and what tension did we refuse to skip?

Chapter 4: Who Was Not in the Room?



Illustration for Chapter 4

The Declaration said “all men.” The room did not have women, enslaved people, or Indigenous people. The gap is the history.

Objective. The student can name one group whose voice was missing from the founding documents and describe how the document would have been different if they had been in the room.

For the grown-up in the room. Honest, not theatrical. Do not dismiss the founding. Do not baptize it. Name one missing voice. Stop. Do not ask the model to speak for the missing voices. The model cannot. The missing voices are in real people, real texts, real histories. Find those. The model is a summary, not a voice.

This sitting applies the missing-voices skill from the thinking unit to the founding. The Declaration says “all men.” The room that wrote it had no women, no enslaved people, no Indigenous people, no people without property. The documents reflect the room. The gap is the history. Name one missing group and imagine how the document would have been different. Not to dismiss the founding. To read it honestly. The citizen who can name the missing voices has read the founding as a citizen, not as a fan.

The Declaration was written by a room of men, most of whom owned property, some of whom enslaved people. The document says “all men are created equal.” The room that wrote it did not include all people. The gap between the words and the room is the history. If enslaved people had been in the room, would the document have said “all men”? You may not get a clever essay. You should get an honest pause.

Keep it concrete. One group. One difference. Do not drown the sitting in every crime of the eighteenth century. Do not pretend the room was full.

A model summary often skips the empty chairs. If it recites equality and never names the room, that is the drop. You name the chairs. Compression is not neutral.

Emerging will name two missing voices and find one real source: Frederick Douglass’s “What to the Slave Is the Fourth of July?”, Abigail Adams’s “Remember the Ladies” letter, or an Indigenous speech or treaty. The model cannot provide the missing voice. The student finds it in a real text. You may hear one sentence of Douglass tonight so you know a missing voice spoke back, in public, with a date. You are not doing the full emerging source hunt unless the grown-up chooses a short text.

Adult reads one missing-voice text alongside a founding document and names the gap. “The founding said this. The missing voice says this. Both are the republic.” You are building the seating chart those later sittings assume.

If they say “That was a long time ago.”: It is in the paper we still use. Old is not the same as gone.

If they say “Then the paper is bad.”: The paper claimed a promise and broke it in the same room. Citizens keep the promise and name the break. Throwing the paper away without reading it is another skip.

If they say “We can’t judge the past by today’s standards.”: This is not judgment. This is reading. The room did not include everyone. That is a fact, not a judgment. Naming the fact is literacy. Judging is a separate act. Read first. Judge later, if you want. Do not skip the reading.

If they say “I can just ask the model what the missing voices said.”: You can ask for a summary. The summary is not the voice. Read the actual text. The model summarizes. The text speaks.

“I desire you would Remember the Ladies, and be more generous and favourable to them than your ancestors.” — Abigail Adams to John Adams, 31 March 1776

That letter is one page. It is a missing voice speaking to the room in the same year as the Declaration. Cite the letter, not a recap of the letter.

“What, to the American slave, is your 4th of July? I answer; a day that reveals to him, more than all other days in the year, the gross injustice and cruelty to which he is the constant victim.” — Frederick Douglass, “What to the Slave Is the Fourth of July?” (Rochester, 5 July 1852)

Douglass did not reject the Declaration. He used it. He held the nation to its own standard. That is the other half of the republic, not a cancellation of the first half.

Sitting big idea. The founding was written by a room that did not include everyone. The gap between the words and the room is the history.

Integrity. Do not ask the model to speak for the missing voices. Cite the real text.

Hard edges. Do not make this a dismissal of the founding. The point is honest reading, not rejection. Keep it concrete: name one group, describe one difference.

Big Idea

The founding claims universality and was written by a partial room. Naming the empty chairs is literacy, not guilt theater. Completeness is the sitting. Rejection without reading is another skip.

Try This

1. Read the opening of the Declaration. “All men are created equal.” 2. Draw a table. “In the room” / “Not in the room.” Fill it with the grown-up. 3. Ask: if enslaved people had been in

the room, would the document have said “all men”? Write one sentence of answer. 4. Read the Adams sentence or the Douglass sentence above. Write: this is a missing voice speaking back. Cite the real text. 5. Ask the model to summarize the Declaration in one paragraph. Did it name the empty chairs? If not, that is the lesson.

Talk About It

1. Who was not in the room when the founding was written, and how would it have been different? 2. Why is “products of their time” not an excuse to skip reading the people who were also of that time and said so? 3. Who is missing from a room we sit in now, and do we notice?

What missing voice did we actually cite, and what page did it sit beside?

Chapter 5: The Republic Can Change



Illustration for Chapter 5

The Constitution was not finished when it was written. It has been changed 27 times. The change is built into the design.

Objective. The student can explain what an amendment is, name one amendment that changed the republic, and describe how the document can change.

For the grown-up in the room. Pick one amendment you can tell truly in five sentences. Do not survey all twenty-seven. Do not pretend amendment is easy. The Fourteenth is its own figure booklet on this academy — do not steal that pack tonight. If you need a voting story, choose the Nineteenth (women) or the Twenty-sixth (eighteen-year-olds). One story. Not a timeline poster.

The people who wrote the Constitution knew it was not perfect. They included a process to change it: the amendment. An amendment is a change to the document. It requires agreement from Congress and the states. It is hard, but it is possible. The first ten amendments are the Bill of Rights. The 13th amendment ended slavery as a constitutional fact. The 14th gave citizenship. The 19th gave women the vote. The 26th lowered the voting age. The document you inherit is not only 1787. It is 1787 plus the changes citizens forced.

A design that cannot change is a trap. Article V is the path. If someone says “it’s outdated” and walks away, that is a complaint. If someone learns how it changes and uses that path, that is a citizen. Both feelings are allowed. Only one is the practice.

A model will list amendments. You name one change and what it fixed or failed to fix. Lists without a named change are trivia.

“The Congress, whenever two thirds of both Houses shall deem it necessary, shall propose Amendments to this Constitution, or, on the Application of the Legislatures of two thirds of the several States, shall call a Convention for proposing Amendments...”
— Constitution of the United States, Article V

Hard on purpose. Many hands. Not one king.

“Neither slavery nor involuntary servitude, except as a punishment for crime whereof the party shall have been duly convicted, shall exist within the United States, or any place subject to their jurisdiction.” — Amendment XIII (1865)

The 13th reveals that slavery was in the original design. The amendment is the republic changing its mind. Cite the amendment, not a recap of the Civil War.

“The right of citizens of the United States to vote shall not be denied or abridged by the United States or by any State on account of sex.” — Amendment XIX (1920)

The 19th reveals that women were not originally included as voters. One amendment. Five true sentences. Not a timeline of twenty-seven. If you point at the Fourteenth, point at the figure booklet and stop. That pack is already gold. This spine does not re-pack it.

“All persons born or naturalized in the United States, and subject to the jurisdiction thereof, are citizens of the United States and of the State wherein they reside.” — Amendment XIV, Section 1 (1868)

That sentence is the citizenship clause. Read it once so you know the words exist. Then leave the rest of the Fourteenth to its own six sittings. Do not turn tonight into that pack.

| Change | What the words do | What they admit | |---|---|---| | Article V | How the paper changes | 1787 was not finished | | Amendment XIII | Ends slavery as a constitutional fact | Slavery was in the design | | Amendment XIX | Votes may not be denied on account of sex | The original room left women out |

Emerging names three amendments and the gaps they closed. You name one and write the gap. The table is a map, not a test.

Emerging treats amendment as civic practice: describe the process, name three amendments that changed the republic, and explain how amendment connects to the founding’s promise. Adult reads one amendment with the child and names the gap it closed. “The 13th amendment ended slavery. Slavery was in the original design. The amendment changed the design.” You need one picture: the paper is not a stone tablet. Citizens can still write on it, slowly, with many hands.

If they say “The Constitution is set in stone.”: It is not. It has been changed 27 times. The change is built into the design. Read Article V. The stone can be shaped by the people.

If they say “Changing it is too hard.”: Hard is the design. A king’s pen is easy. Easy is how you get a new king. 27 amendments have passed. The difficulty is not impossibility.

If they say “We should just write a new one.”: Then you still have to agree. Article V is one path for agreeing. Walking away from every path is not a new constitution. It is leaving the table.

If they say “The original Constitution was fine.”: It included slavery. It excluded women. It counted enslaved people as three-fifths. The amendments fixed parts of that. The citizen who says “fine” without reading the amendments has not read the gaps. Read both.

Sitting big idea. The Constitution was designed to change. 27 amendments prove it. The republic is a practice, not a relic.

Integrity. Cite the amendment and the article. Do not present a model summary as the source. The text is the source.

Hard edges. Do not make this a memorization of all 27 amendments. Name one or two that changed the republic. The 13th, 14th, and 15th are the Reconstruction amendments. Name them if you name the Civil War. Do not steal the Fourteenth figure pack.

Big Idea

Amendment is the republic changing its design to match its promise. The difficulty is a feature. The citizen who only complains that it is old, and never opens Article V, has not practiced.

Try This

1. Read Article V. It is short. Write in your own words: who has to agree. 2. Name one amendment that changed the republic: the 13th (end of slavery), the 19th (women's vote), or the 14th (citizenship — point to the figure booklet, do not convert it). 3. Write the gap it closed in one sentence. 4. If they say it is too old to bother with: "Then we use the change path, or we are only complaining." 5. Dinner: What change did we name, and who had to agree?

Talk About It

1. What amendment did we learn about today, and how did it change the republic? 2. Why did the designers make change hard on purpose? 3. What is one rule in our house that we changed, and who had to agree?

What gap did the amendment close, and what gap did it leave?

Chapter 6: You Are a Citizen



Illustration for Chapter 6

You read the words, saw the design, named the missing voices, and learned the republic can change. Now: what does a citizen do?

Objective. The student can name one thing a citizen does (read the documents, name a gap, speak, vote) and explain why it matters.

For the grown-up in the room. Mark done only if the student (or you, with them) read actual words first. A video recap is not the sitting. A model dump is not the sitting. Do not make this a political lecture. The point is the practice of citizenship, not a position. Keep it to one thing a citizen does.

This is the capstone for the young band. The student has learned to read the words, see the design, name the missing voices, and understand amendment. Now the question: what does a citizen do? The citizen reads the documents. The citizen names the gaps. The citizen speaks. The citizen votes. Name one of these and explain why it matters. The capstone is the connection between reading the founding and acting as a citizen. The reading is the foundation. The action is the citizenship.

A citizen is not a mascot. A citizen reads, names gaps, sees the design, and does not outsource the reading. Capstone is not a quiz. Capstone is doing one small civic act with a grown-up: read a page, write what it says, name one drop in a summary, name one missing voice, and stop.

Do not let a model write the paragraph. If the model writes it, the name on the page is a lie. Integrity here is the same as every WisdomForge sitting: the try is yours. The tool is second. A grown-up is nearby. If MINE is empty — no sentence in their hand — redo or disclose. Do not turn in a model paragraph with their name on it.

You are not asked to love 1776. You are asked not to fake having read it. You are not asked to hate 1787. You are asked to see the machine, including the ugly gears. That is enough for this band.

Emerging capstone is the full cycle: read a founding document, audit the design, name the missing voices, connect to an amendment, and name one citizen act they will take. Adult runs that cycle at the table. You are building the habit those later sittings assume: a page, a gap, a named chair, a grown-up nearby.

If they say “I’m too young to be a citizen.”: You are not too young to read the documents. You are not too young to name the gaps. You are not too young to speak. The voting comes later. The rest starts now.

If they say “We’ll figure it out as we go.”: That is how you get a leak. Spec first — here, the spec is the page.

If they say “This is a lot for one sitting.”: The first time, it is. The cycle is the investment. The second time is faster. The third is a habit.

If they say “I’m not political.”: Citizenship is not a party. It is the practice of reading your founding, naming its gaps, and acting as a member of the republic. You can do that without a platform.

“We the People...” — Constitution of the United States, Preamble

People. Not a tool. Not a recap. People who read.

Sitting big idea. A citizen reads, names, speaks, and votes. The reading is the foundation. The action is the citizenship.

Integrity. The citizen act must be real. “Read the documents” is real. “Name a gap” is real. Do not name something you will not do. Name what you will do.

Hard edges. Do not make this a political lecture. Keep it to one thing a citizen does. The point is the practice, not the list.

Big Idea

Citizenship at this age is a practice: words first, speech heard, design seen, missing voices named, change possible. The guide is optional. The parent is the teacher. The booklet is the text. The try is first. If the page was skipped, the sitting is not complete.

Try This

1. One page: Declaration first paragraph *or* Constitution preamble. Read aloud. 2. Write what it says. No extra meaning. 3. Model summary. Circle one drop. 4. Name one empty chair. Name one way the paper can change. 5. Name one citizen act you will actually do this month: READ / NAME / SPEAK. (Vote waits until you can.) 6. Dinner: What did we actually read this week, and what did we refuse to skip?

Talk About It

1. What is one thing a citizen does, and why does it matter? 2. If a tool wrote the paragraph, whose name belongs on it? 3. When did a grown-up last read a real civic page, not a recap, in front of you?

What did we actually read this week, and what did we refuse to skip?

Six labs, one week (optional map)

Use this only if the chapters already ran. It is not six extra sittings.

Lab 1 — Words. One Declaration sentence. Write what it says. Summary second.

Lab 2 — Speech. Read aloud. Point to speak / list / feel.

Lab 3 — Design. Three cards. One check. Name three-fifths without a speech.

Lab 4 — Room. Table of in / not in. One missing group. Cite Adams or Douglass, not a model.

Lab 5 — Change. One amendment, five sentences. Article V on the table.

Lab 6 — Whole sitting. One page, one drop, one empty chair, one real act, stop.

If you skip a day, do not stack two labs to “catch up.” One first hand is the week.

| Practice | First hand | Tool, if any | |---|---|---| | Words | Read the sentence | Summary as a catch, not the source | | Speech | Hear it | Labels after you point | | Design | Sort the jobs | Explain-the-design, not a list | | Room | Name empty chairs | Recap often skips them — that is data | | Change | One amendment story | List of 27 is trivia | | Capstone | One page together | Model does not write the paragraph |

Eleven-to-fourteen will meet founding recaps in search whether you install Hermes or not. This booklet does not make that safe. It makes a check you can run. Safety theater is not the sitting. The sitting is the page and the gap.

If they hide a tool, that is the miss even when the recap is “right.” If they refuse the tool for a week and still read the page, that week is complete. If they refuse the page, that week is not.

You are not asked to become a constitutional lawyer tonight. You are asked to hear a recap as a recap.

Integrity for the week: if a tool was used, say so. If the page was skipped, do not mark the sitting complete. If the student is tired, stop. A half page read honestly beats a full recap performed.

Transfer: Thinking (source before summary; missing voices), English (the Declaration as speech; Rhetoric in the Age of Fluency), CS (the Constitution as a spec with a refuse-list). Keep those as dinner pointers, not extra chapters.

For the Grown-Up Reader

Six live academy sittings (`words-before-story` through `citizens-capstone`), young / emerging / adult. Little sitting **404** by design. This middle band is the young variants in `history-civics.ts`, with emerging named as the later audit so the student knows the next

seat exists. Primary text: Declaration of Independence (1776) and Constitution of the United States (1787), including Article I's three-fifths clause, the fugitive slave clause in Article IV, and Article V. Rhetoric lens uses Aristotle's three appeals as named in the sitting, not as a full *Rhetoric* course.

Missing-voice texts cited: Abigail Adams to John Adams, 31 March 1776; Frederick Douglass, "What to the Slave Is the Fourth of July?", Rochester, 5 July 1852. Amendments cited: XIII (1865). The Fourteenth remains its own figure booklet. Do not convert it here.

This is not the Hour book. It is not Federalist / Magna Carta / Constitution / Declaration / Fourteenth *figure* booklets. Those remain their own packs. No real family data. Do not clone an adult profile into a child's. Nearby means you can hear the lid. It does not mean you write their sentence.

If you only run one lab this week, run chapter 1's sentence. Keep the gap. That gap is worth more than a speech about 1787.

Do not grade their soul. Do not make the model the first read of a live assignment. Do not skip the ugly clauses "until they are older" if you are already reading the pretty ones. The skip teaches that citizenship is only the parts that feel good.

If they hide a tool, that is the miss even when the recap is "right." If they refuse the tool for a week and still read the page, that week is complete. If they refuse the page, that week is not. You are not asked to become a constitutional lawyer tonight. You are asked to hear a recap as a recap.

Dinner questions already live on the sittings, keep them: What words did we read today from the founding, and what did the summary miss? Which appeal in the Declaration was strongest, and which was weakest? What part of the design did we see, and what bargain did we name? Who was not in the room when the founding was written, and how would it have been different? What amendment did we learn about today, and how did it change the republic? What is one thing a citizen does, and why does it matter?

If "They won't understand the old language": they will understand more than you think. The language is old, not opaque. Read it slowly. Stop and ask: "What does this sentence say?" They will tell you. The understanding comes from the reading, not from a modern translation that already chose. If "I don't want to read the ugly parts with my child": then the child learns that citizenship skips the ugly parts. That is propaganda. Read them. Name them. Say: "This is in the foundation. We read it because it is ours, not because it is good." The honesty is the citizenship.

National Archives texts of the Declaration and Constitution are public domain. Read from those, not from a chatbot's memory of them. If your printout and the model disagree, the printout wins. Cite the document. Always the document, never the recap as the source.

Pauline Maier's *American Scripture* (1997) is the adult reminder that the Declaration was not treated as holy writ in 1776; it was a political document that became scripture later. You do not need Maier at the table. You need the page. Danielle Allen's *Our Declaration* (2014) is a slow reading of political equality; again, the sitting is the sentence, not the secondary book. Gordon Wood and Charles Beard disagree about whether the Constitution is primarily a republican experiment or an economic bargain. Name that adult fight only if it helps you refuse a cleaned-up story. Do not assign Beard to an 11-year-old.

About WisdomForge

This is the middle band of *Citizens — Constitution & Declaration*. Payment pulled. No purchase CTA. The booklet is the text. The parent is the teacher. The guide is optional. Not a hosted kids chatbot. Does not make AI safe.

Four ages, one spine. Elementary, high, and adult bands of this pack are separate files. Little academy sittings stay 404 on purpose. Pair from `/learn/young/history/words-before-story` when you want the live sitting beside this text. Print the page. Pencil first. Tool second.